My Boyfriend's Back and There's Gonna be Laundry

By Sandra Shamas

SANDRA: I'd like to start the evening off by offering you a performance art piece. I'm holding in my hands a sturdy pair of men's cotton briefs. Now, many of you won't even recognize these; so nice and flat and ***white,*** like this. Maybe I can help you recognize them, if I wad them up into a tight angry little ball. Maybe you'll recognize them better in their natural habitat: the floor.

INTRODUCTION

Being single sucks. Feeling as if you are not wanted, wondering if you are, in fact, too needy, expect too much, or aren't worthy of being with anyone period. It's a battle virtually every woman has had to conquer. But Sandra Shamas brings this single-womanhood dilemma home better than anyone else. Join me for a couple of weeks in the life of a single woman and I think you'll recognize exactly where she's coming from.

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SANDRA: Now, when you go to the magazine rack and you see the entire world of magazines that are available to women, all these magazines are pretty much the same. There's a wide variety of topics on each cover. You find "Fashion Tips," "Thin Thighs in 30 Days," "Lose 30 Pounds in Two Weeks," or little psychological pieces like "Five Things Men Fear." Inevitably, on the front cover of one of these magazines, there'll be an article entitled something like, "The Joy of Being Single." Biggest oxymoron in the world. A contradiction in terms. Like "jumbo shrimp," or "military intelligence."

Now, these articles are there to help you be better at being single. 'Cause you're just not doing a good enough job. And they make suggestions to single women like, "take brisk walks," and "don't be afraid to dine alone." Have you ever done this? Have you ever dined alone? Okay. You go. You're upright. You're bathed. You're dressed.

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You're standing in front of the "Please wait to be seated" sign. The hostess comes over with a fan of menus, and she gives you that "Oh, you-poor-piece-of-s***, you-couldn't-find-anybody-to-eat-with-you" look, takes you to a table for two by the toilet, hands you one menu, and then abandons you. Because whatever you've got might be catching.

I eat over the sink. I dine alone with the sink. The nice, stainless steel placemat for one. I take the pot off the stove. I go to the sink. And I dine alone! But when I decided to be single, I envisioned my singledom to be a lot more romantic. In my singleness, I was a little taller, and willowy. And I wore a lot of white, gauzy cotton clothes that wafted around me. And my hair was shorter, but tawny-coloured. And I don't even know what colour that is. But whenever I read a Harlequin romance, the heroine always has "green, flashing eyes, and tawny hair." I WANT IT!

So, what happens? What happens? You know, I turned my head away for a second, and into my life walks this guy. The one. He was, *the one.* How did I know he was *the one?* Because when I looked at this guy, I heard an operatic version of *Star Trek* music in my head. He was tall and lean and blond, blue-eyed, funny, bright, articulate . . . and younger. You get them young, you can train them. And his name was Frank. I fell in love with Frank. Now, I don't know about you, but when I fall in love, I give my brain . . . AWAY.

Nobody -- especially other single women -- wants to be around a woman who has just fallen in love. No. Well, you know why. It's because her voice goes up three octaves, it takes on a sickening sing-songy quality, and the sum total of her conversation is:

GUSHING WOMAN: And then you know what else he said? And he's so funny, and he's so smart. And, also, he's not like any man I've ever met before in my whole life. And he's so smart and he's so funny. You know what he said?

SANDRA: ***AH, SHUT UP!*** So there I was. I was in love love love love love. So, one day, the phone rings. "Hello." (It's Frank.) "Hiyee. How are you? What? Oh, I'd love to get together. It's so funny' cause I was just thinking about you and then the phone rings.

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Weird, eh? .. What? No, let's get together. I'd love that. Let's have coffee. Yeah . . . I know where it is . . . Yeah. I can be there in fifteen minutes . . . No problem. Okay. Bye . . . What? Oh, I'd love to talk to you, too . . . Okay . . . I'll see you there in fifteen . . . Okay. Bye-bye. . ." *(pause)* "Uh? No, you hang up first. Okay, we'll count together. "One . . . two . . . "

I go to the cafe. Frank is already there. He is already sitting at a table for two. He has already ordered coffee. He's very handsome. And so I go and sit across from him. "Hello!" And he says seriously,

FRANK: Hi . . . um . . . thanks, ah . . . thanks very much for coming.

SANDRA: No trouble.

FRANK: Look, um . . . there's no easy way for me to say this . . .

SANDRA: Oh, then don't say it.

FRANK: Yeah, um . . . you know, ah . . . you know, I've, ah . . . I've been doing some thinking. . . and, ah. . . something I want you to know, it's not you, you know. But I really feel like things are going way too fast for me right now and I'm not ready, at all, to make any kind . . . of emotional . . . com . . . mit. . . ment.

SANDRA: Well, sing along if you know the words. Right away all the blood in my body went right into my head, and I could hear my heart in my ears. And nausea. And I'm looking right at him as hard as I can, I'm looking dead at him, and all I see is his mouth moving and no sound coming out. That voice in my head and says,

VOICE IN S's HEAD: "DON'T LET *HIM* SEE YOU CRY!"

SANDRA: Tears come. (to herself) I can't help it. I can't help it.

VOICE IN S's HEAD: STAND UP!

SANDRA: Okay. I'm up . . .

VOICE IN S's HEAD: GO TO THE DOOR!

SANDRA: I don't know where the door is!

VOICE IN S's HEAD: IT'S OVER THERE!

SANDRA: Oh, please. Please. What if he changes his mind?

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VOICE IN S's HEAD: HE HASN'T GOT A MIND TO CHANGE! GET OUTTA HERE!

SANDRA: So, where do you go? Where do you go when somebody says, "I'm not here for you anymore? Sorry!" Where do you go? Well, I don't know about you, but I like to turn my head down the path of self-destruction.

I'm diggin' in. I'm diggin' in for Stinky Pyjama Time. Stinky Pyjama Time. Maybe you know it. It does not have to be pyjamas. It can be bad track pants. Regardless, the outfit is a legged garment with the crotch way down around your knees. And you wear that with a completely mismatched top. Oh, [and] we never bathe during Stinky Pyjama Time. We never shave our legs. And if you're in SPT long enough, you can actually get the hair on your legs to start doing that giant kelp action in the tub.

Two weeks. Two weeks go by, and every day, I walk up and down the hall, crying. Sometimes, the phone would ring. I would answer it, but before I could talk I'd have to cough up a big hairball so the words could come out.

(on the phone) Hello? Oh, hi, Maria . . . No, no, man, I can't go out. . . Oh, yeah? . . . Yeah? . . . Where did you see him? . . . Oh, you had a party? At your house? . . . I didn't know you were having a party . . . Oh, yeah? . . . Maria, did it look like he was with somebody? . . . Oh, yeah? . . . Did it look like he'd been crying for two weeks?"

No.

Now, whenever I want to take my mind off love lost, I do the laundry. I don't know what it is; I think it's just my need to be clean or to be in the basement communing with trolls. One or the other. Or both.

Now I'm still deep in Stinky Pyjama mode, but the light at the end of the tunnel comes by way of a fresh basket of laundry I've just done. So, the ironing board goes up. The iron starts getting hot. And I'm rummaging around in the basket . . . and whose shirt comes out? Frank's.

So, I lay it really lovingly on the ironing board, and I think, *Okay, he'll see that this shirt is*

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not at his house, and he'll come here. And he'll come here and he'll see that it's here and that I ironed it, and he'll say, "Oh, Sandra, I should never have left you because you're such a good ironer.

NEVER! Never, never, ever has a man gone for a woman because of her domestic prowess.

So, I'm at the board and I'm feeling so sad. And I'm crying and crying, and I'm thinking, *It's me. It's because* if *me. If I were way more excellent, he would never have left. That's it. If I were way more excellent, he would never have left.*

Think of something else! Think of something else . . . The phone rings. I shuffle over. "Hello." (It's Frank) "Oh, hello . . . No, I don't mind you calling . . . No, I wasn't doing anything, I was just, um . . . standing . . . How am I? Oh, I'm ***fine*** . . . Couldn't be better . . . Meet you for coffee? .. Yeah, I suppose I could meet you. . .in fifteen minutes . . . " (I catch a whiff of myself) "Make it sixteen . . . Okay . . . Bye."

Come on, Sandra, pull yourself together . . . C'mon. You can do it. . . I wanna go because I wanna see him but I don't wanna go because I'm afraid. No, I'm gonna cry . . . No. No. No crying. No crying!

So, I'm out the door, going towards the cafe, and I'm doing that shuffling, crying s***, you know, where there's heavy snot bubble action. I'm afraid to see him, but then I figure, he can only dump me once. I get to the cafe, and Frank is already sitting there at our table for two. He's already ordered coffee. He's very handsome, and he's beckoning for me to join him, so I do.

So, I sit across from him, and he says,

FRANK: Hi. Hi. It's really good to see you. You know . . . the last two weeks have been pretty hard on me. I was at the bookshop and I saw a book you were looking for and I knew you would love it and . . . uh . . . I couldn't call you. And late at night if I couldn't get to sleep, I'd go for a walk and sometimes I'd pass in front of your house

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and I'd see the light on in the living room and I'd think, maybe if I just looked in the window, I'd get to see her. . . . the truth of it is . . . I didn't expect to miss you . . . and I did. And I know I've got no right to ask, and I know I sound like a jerk, . . . but, is there any way you can see past what's happened and maybe give us a second . . .

SANDRA: "YES!" . . . chance?"

SANDRA: You know, I like to think I hesitated a milli-second on that. So, we sat and we talked and talked and talked and talked and when the waitress came over, I put my brain on her tray. We had coffee after coffee after coffee and Frank quickly said

FRANK: Listen, do you want to go for a walk?

SANDRA: And we went out into that near perfect autumn night: clear, stars, crisp, beautiful. We walked and talked and walked and we ended up in front of my house. *(to Frank)* Gee, Frank, you know . . . do you feel like coming in and having a coffee? *(to audience)* So, we both go into the house and it's incredibly awkward. A remarkably awkward moment: we're standing in the living room and we both have our coats on. So Frank says, in an effort to break the ice,

FRANK: Why don't we see what's on TV?

SANDRA: Yeah, that's a great idea. *(to audience)* And we both reach down for the converter at the very same time, and our hands touch, and there's like this arc of electricity. Frank says,

FRANK: THE LAST ONE TO THE BEDROOM'S A DIRTY ROTTEN EGG!

SANDRA: And the bed has fresh sheets. I just did the laundry. Sometimes, God says "Yes."

The next morning, he had an early call, and he was gone at about seven. So I was alone in bed, and I was in that warm, rosy glow that only women really know. And I was so happy that my boyfriend was back. (Yay! Yay!) And I sat up in bed to start my day, and I just happened to look down on the floor. And there, there in the corner of the bedroom, on the floor, was his dirty underwear. And I thought to myself, *Oh, I get it. My boyfriend's back, and there's gonna be laundry.*

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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